

Sports Nutrition Supplement Market in Germany and Europe

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Executive Summary

Europe's sports nutrition market is expanding steadily and moving firmly into the mainstream, with Germany among the largest and fastest-growing national markets; protein remains the revenue anchor while RTD shakes, bars, plant-based lines, collagen, and hydration products add new users and occasions across drugstores, grocers, e-commerce, and gyms.

Demand is led by goals such as energy, post-exercise recovery, strength/muscle growth, hydration, and endurance, and is strongest among younger consumers and increasingly among women, reflecting a shift from athlete-only positioning to everyday performance-plus-wellness routines; purchase decisions hinge on affordability, trusted brands, natural ingredients, taste, and convenience. The competitive field mixes global corporations with agile European specialists; brand playbooks that win combine a hero protein platform, premium RTD or bar for convenience, clean-label and plant-based extensions, and evidence-led messaging that stays compliant with EU health-claim rules and German labeling/notification requirements under LFGB/NemV, with EFSA-authorized wording for any claims used.

Western Europe shows high online penetration alongside strong offline placement, so omnichannel execution is essential: use DTC and marketplaces for education, reviews, subscriptions, and bundles, while building retail velocity through drugstores (dm, Rossmann) and grocers (REWE, Edeka) with chilled RTDs and front-of-store displays; pharmacies and specialists remain critical for premium and certified lines.

Typical price bands cluster around €25–€45 for mainstream 1 kg powders (higher for isolates/specialty), €2–€4 for RTDs, €1.5–€3 for bars, and €10–€30 for common vitamins, with promo-heavy DTC players driving price pressure and private label intensifying margin risk in commodity powders. Key risks are strict EU/German compliance on claims and novel ingredients, crowded assortments with heavy discounting, and retailer listing hurdles; mitigation includes early regulatory checks, third-party testing where relevant, differentiated flavors/benefits, and localized launch plans with sampling and micro-influencer/coach programs.

Recommended actions: anchor the portfolio with one flagship protein and one convenience hero (RTD or bar), add plant-based and collagen to reach new segments, build compliant education content and athlete/coach partnerships, structure DTC subscriptions and marketplace PPC for repeat, and target dm/Rossmann plus leading grocers for national reach in Germany while preparing NemV notification and EU-authorized claim copy before launch.

Market overview

Europe's sports nutrition market is large, growing steadily, and moving from a niche for athletes to an everyday wellness category, with Germany among the top contributors by size and momentum.

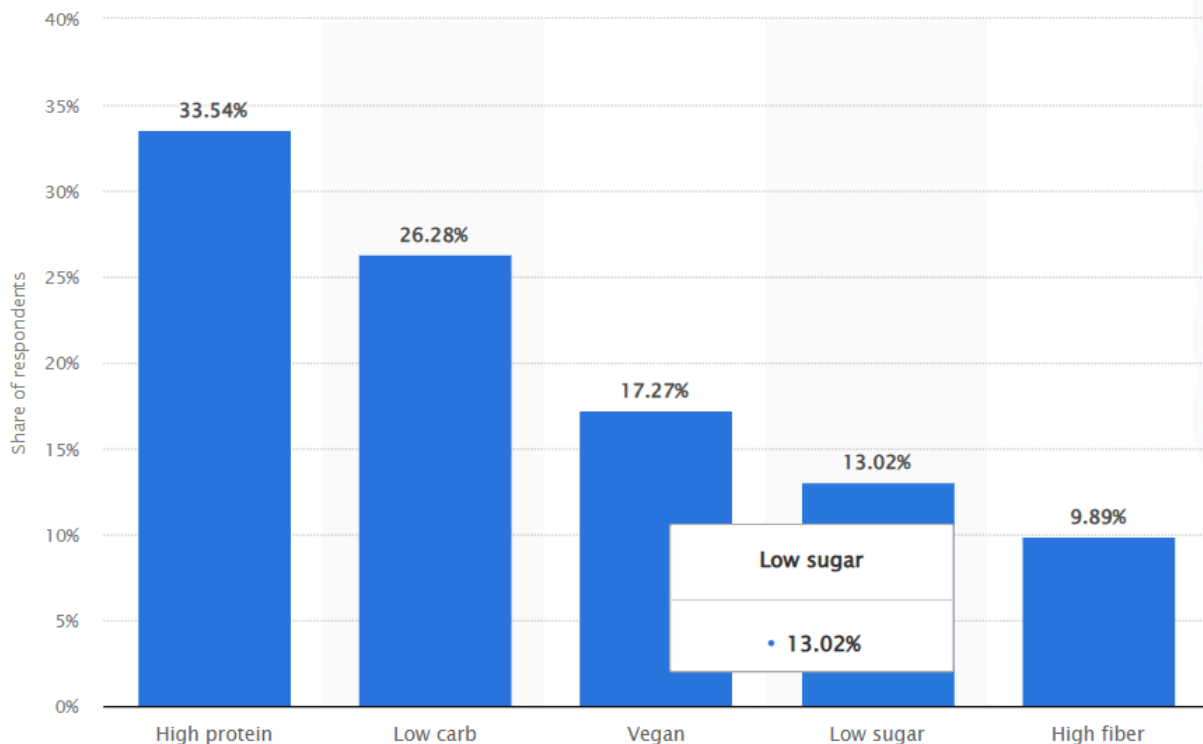
Europe at a glance

Between 2004 and 2018, the global sports nutrition market grew by about 190%, with an average yearly growth rate of around 7.9%. After the pandemic, demand kept rising as more people became health-conscious and retail prices increased, driving stronger sales in Europe. Today, most forecasts suggest that the European market will continue growing at about 5–9% per year through the late 2020s. Growth could be even higher if premium ready-to-drink products (RTDs) and online sales expand faster than expected.

As of 2024–2025, the European sports nutrition market is valued at roughly USD 6 to 6.7 billion, and it's expected to keep climbing at a steady mid- to high-single-digit pace for the rest of the decade. This growth is being fueled by the category's shift into mainstream wellness, wider product ranges, and strong e-commerce momentum.

Western Europe is leading the charge thanks to its well-developed fitness culture, high online shopping activity, and broader retail presence for protein-rich foods and drinks. Sports nutrition in Europe is no longer a niche for athletes; it's now a regular part of the everyday wellness lifestyle, with new users joining through online, supermarket, and drugstore channels.

Which nutritional trend do you find particularly interesting?



[Additional Information](#)

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Source-Statista

Germany at a glance

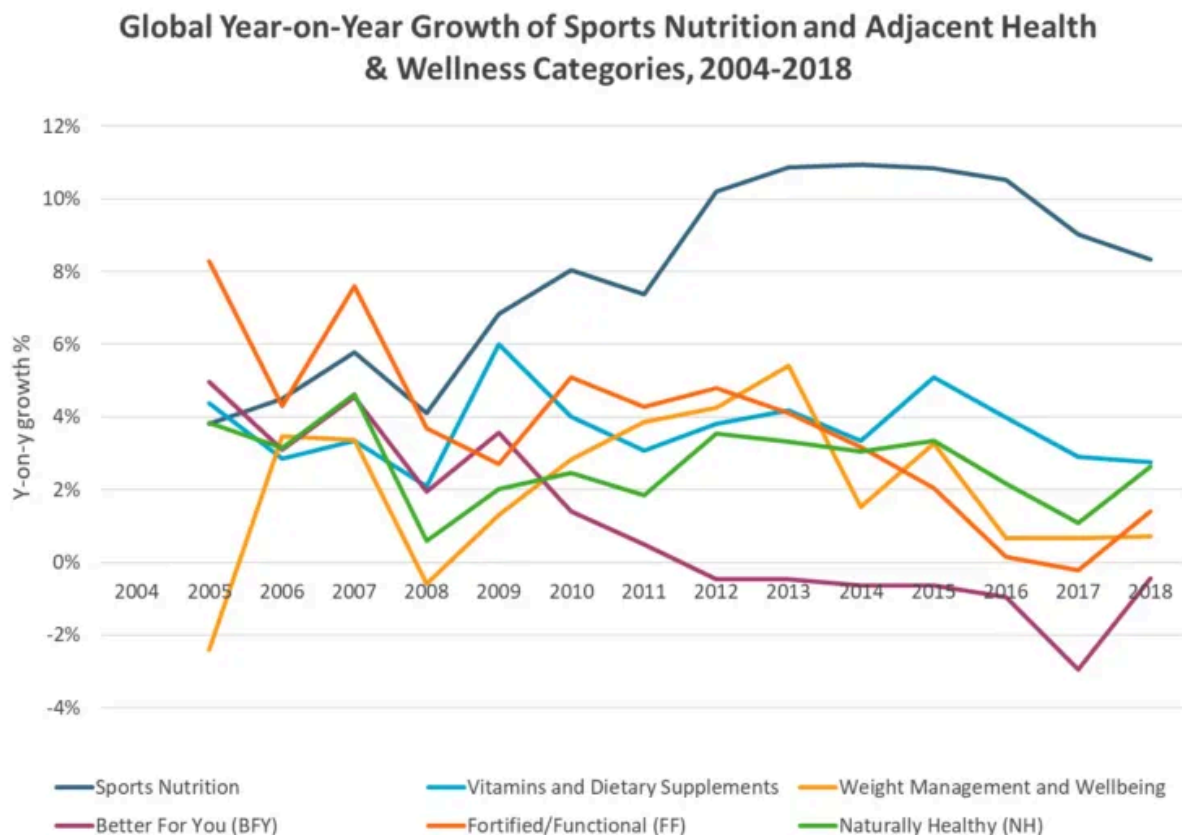
Germany's sports nutrition market was worth around USD 1.09 billion in 2023 and is expected to reach about USD 1.9 billion by 2030, growing at an average annual rate of 8–8.5%. This pace is faster than many other health and wellness categories and puts Germany among the top-performing markets in Europe.

Germany benefits from several structural advantages, strong drugstore chains like dm and Rossmann, successful direct-to-consumer (DTC) brands, and a broad fitness culture that spans gym-goers, runners, and wellness-focused consumers who buy products for everyday health, not just sports performance. Overall,

Germany stands out for both its scale and momentum. Its market is anchored by protein-based products but is rapidly expanding into sports foods and ready-to-drink (RTD) formats. These trends make Germany a key launch market for both affordable DTC brands and premium clean-label products over the next few years.

Growth Driver

- **Broader audience:** Sports nutrition is no longer just for gym-goers; more everyday consumers now use protein powders, RTDs, and bars for energy, recovery, and convenience, expanding the market beyond traditional sports users.
- **Product innovation:** Growth is driven by new options like plant-based protein, collagen, and hydration blends with clearer benefits such as energy, recovery, and endurance, making products more lifestyle-friendly.
- **Strong sales channels:** Western Europe's high online penetration, along with strong sales through drugstores, grocers, and DTC brands, supports steady growth and premium upgrades in RTDs.
- **Protein still leads:** In Germany, protein-based supplements reached about USD 488M in 2024 and are expected to exceed USD 900M by 2032, growing around 8% annually, confirming protein's central role in recovery and everyday nutrition.



Source- Euromonitor

From 2010 onward, sports nutrition clearly led growth among health categories. After slowing to around 2% in 2008 during the global downturn, it rebounded quickly, reaching 6% growth in 2009 and climbing to around 11–12% by 2012–2014. Even though growth eased to about 8% by 2018, it still outperformed other wellness segments like vitamins, weight management, and functional foods, which stayed in the low single digits or even declined.

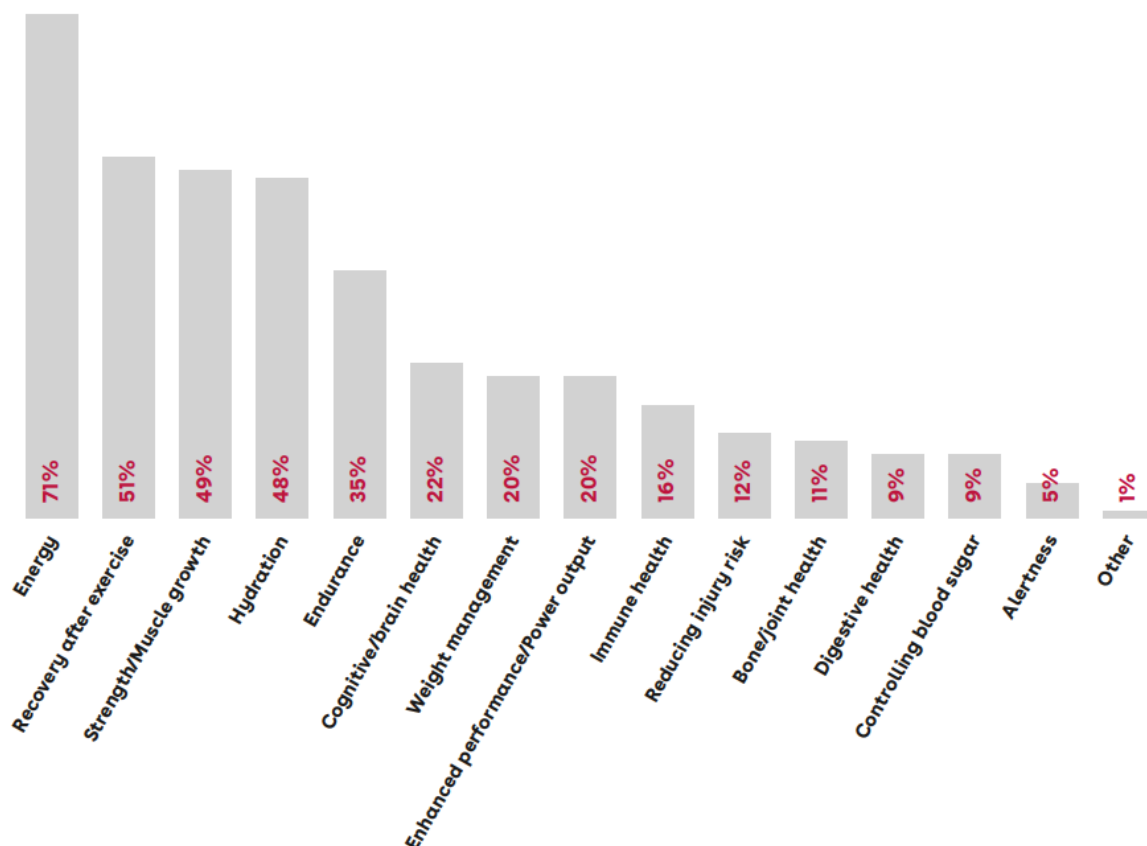
Sports nutrition kept growing through the 2010s because of steady innovation and expanding appeal beyond athletes. New formats such as ready-to-drink shakes and protein bars, along with stronger focus on energy and recovery, attracted a wider audience. Even as the pace of growth slowed, the category maintained a strong lead, showing that by 2018, sports nutrition had become a mainstream wellness product, not just a niche for fitness enthusiasts.

Segmentation by product type

- **Protein-based products** – around 50% of the market
This is the heart of the category, including protein powders, RTD shakes, and protein bars/snacks. Consumers use them for daily nutrition, workout recovery, and meal replacement. Protein powders (whey, casein, and plant-based like pea or soy) remain the largest share thanks to flexibility, value, and taste. RTDs and bars are growing fast as convenient, ready-to-consume formats that fit into busy lifestyles and reach new users beyond gyms.
- **Performance & recovery supplements** – around 25%
Includes amino acids, BCAAs, creatine, and recovery blends designed to improve endurance, strength, and post-workout recovery. Creatine remains a proven performance booster and low-cost staple. Amino acids/BCAAs help with recovery and fatigue. Recovery blends combine protein, carbs, and electrolytes for simplicity after exercise.
- **Energy & focus products** – around 10%
Covers pre-workouts, nootropics, and thermogenic/fat-burning formulas that enhance focus and performance. Most use caffeine, beta-alanine, or adaptogens for energy and alertness. Growth is steady, though marketing is more regulated in the EU.
- **Hydration, collagen, and wellness blends** – around 10%
Includes electrolytes, collagen, and immunity/gut supplements that link sports performance with broader wellness. Electrolytes and hydration drinks benefit from the running and cycling boom. Collagen is popular for joint and skin health, while immunity and gut formulas have remained strong since COVID.
- **Lifestyle and meal replacement products** – around 5%
Covers high-protein meal replacements, functional gummies, and easy daily formats for time-pressed professionals or wellness users. Brands like YFood and Huel lead this trend in Germany.

Segmentation by Health Benefits

Most important goals when using sports nutrition products:



Source-Prinova Europe Ltd.

- **Muscle Building & Recovery** – ~40%
The largest segment, focused on muscle repair, strength, and recovery after workouts. Includes protein powders, RTD shakes, bars, creatine, and recovery blends. Protein both whey/casein and plant-based, dominates this category, making it the foundation for gym-goers and active lifestyle users alike.
- **Energy & Performance** – ~16%
Covers pre-workout and intra-workout formulas that boost energy, focus, and endurance during training. Products often include caffeine, amino acids, and nitric oxide boosters, available in both stimulant and non-stimulant options with improved flavors and mixes.
- **Endurance & Hydration** – ~10%
Includes electrolyte tablets, hydration powders, and light-carb RTDs that help maintain fluid balance and stamina during long workouts, hot weather, or endurance sports like running and cycling.
- **Weight Management** – ~10%
Focuses on high-protein shakes, bars, and satiating blends that support calorie control, muscle tone, and balanced nutrition for active consumers managing body composition.

- **Joint & Recovery Support** – ~7%
Products like collagen powders and recovery supplements target joint comfort, flexibility, and tissue repair, appealing to frequent exercisers and older athletes.
- **General Wellness** – ~10%
Includes multivitamins, minerals, omega-3s, and immunity blends that help active users meet nutritional needs and maintain overall health; often part of subscription bundles or daily routines.
- **Beauty & Collagen** – ~7%
Collagen-based powders, sticks, and gummies that support skin, hair, and nail health while also helping recovery. This crossover between beauty and wellness is growing fast, especially among women.

Awareness and Adoption in Europe and Germany

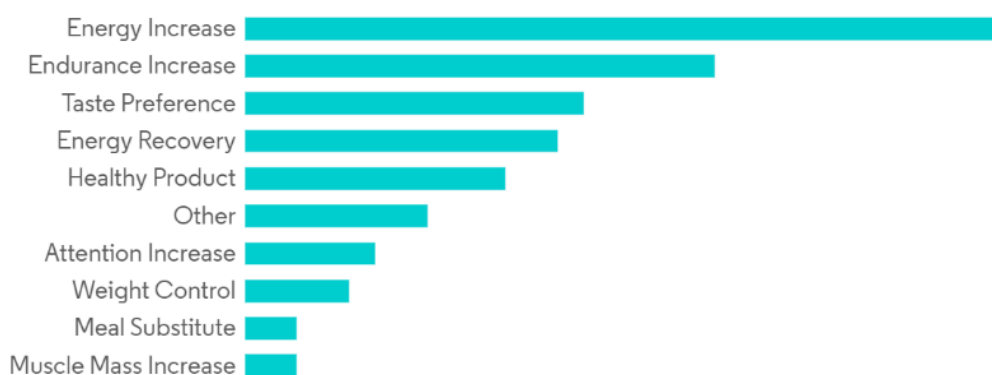
Countries like Germany, the UK, the Nordics, and the Netherlands show the strongest familiarity with sports nutrition. This is driven by active fitness cultures, strong e-commerce use, and wide retail access through supermarkets, drugstores, and online platforms. Sports nutrition in Germany and Western Europe has evolved from a niche for athletes to a mainstream wellness habit, supported by wide availability, strong online education, and growing trust in product quality.

Who's buying:

Younger consumers (Gen Z and millennials) lead adoption, influenced by gym culture, group fitness, and social media that position protein and hydration as everyday wellness staples.

Women are a fast-growing segment, drawn to RTDs, collagen, bars, and clean-label protein options that fit their convenience and lifestyle needs.

Sports Nutrition Market : Different Reasons For Sports Drink Consumption, By Consumer Claims, Germany, 2021



Source: European Commission



Source-Mordor

Why they buy:

Main motivations include energy, endurance, taste, and recovery, followed by general wellness and healthy-lifestyle goals. Consumers now look for complete performance and wellness support, not just muscle gain.

Influence and information:

Gyms, trainers, and fitness clubs remain key advice hubs, while online reviews, social media, and word of mouth are major learning and discovery sources.

Trust is built through transparent labeling, credible claims, and partnerships with sports teams or events that lend authenticity.

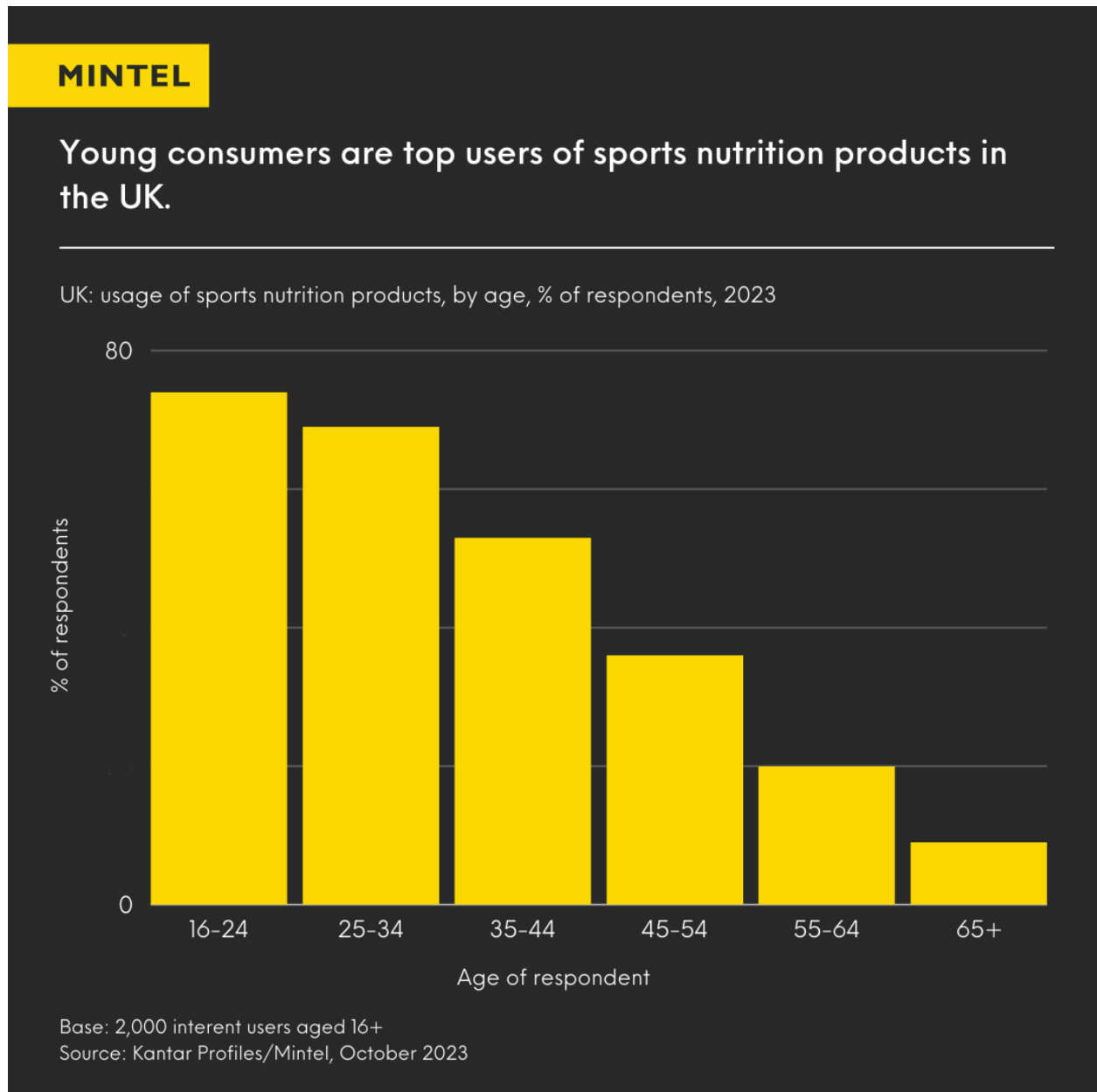
Digital acceleration:

Platforms like Amazon and brand DTC sites simplify discovery with reviews, subscriptions, and bundles, helping newer users, especially women and casual exercisers, find suitable formats easily.

Consumer Analysis

Sports nutrition is attracting a broader audience across Europe and Germany. Beyond gym-goers, adoption is rising among endurance athletes, wellness-focused professionals, and everyday consumers looking for convenient, healthy performance products.

Demographics



Source-Mintel

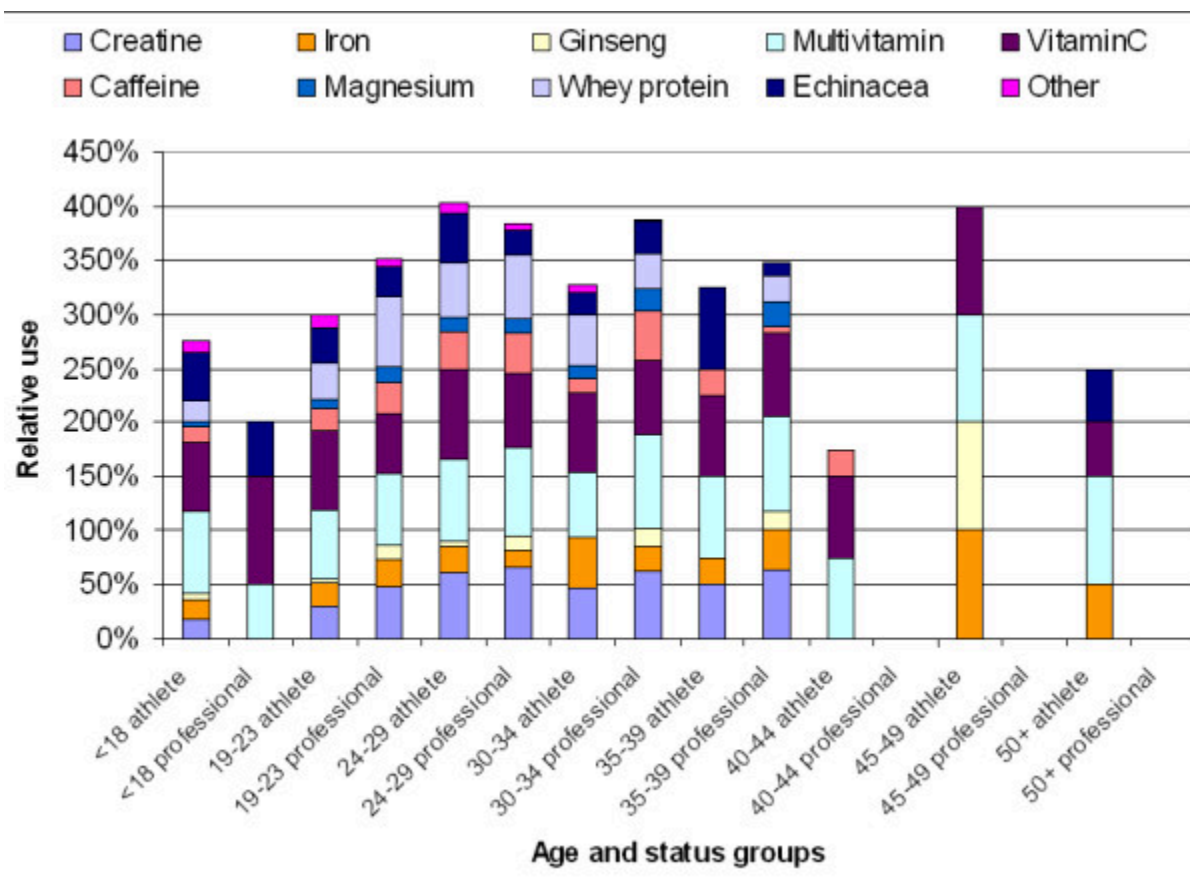
Most users are 18–45 years old, with men still leading in traditional performance products. However, women are rapidly increasing participation, especially in collagen, protein snacks, and RTDs, expanding the market beyond hardcore gym users. Older adults and casual exercisers also contribute, using lighter options like hydration mixes and recovery supplements. Younger consumers (Gen Z, Millennials) are highly influenced by

social media and prefer clean ingredients and convenient formats, focusing on goals like energy, recovery, and strength.

Psychographic Segments

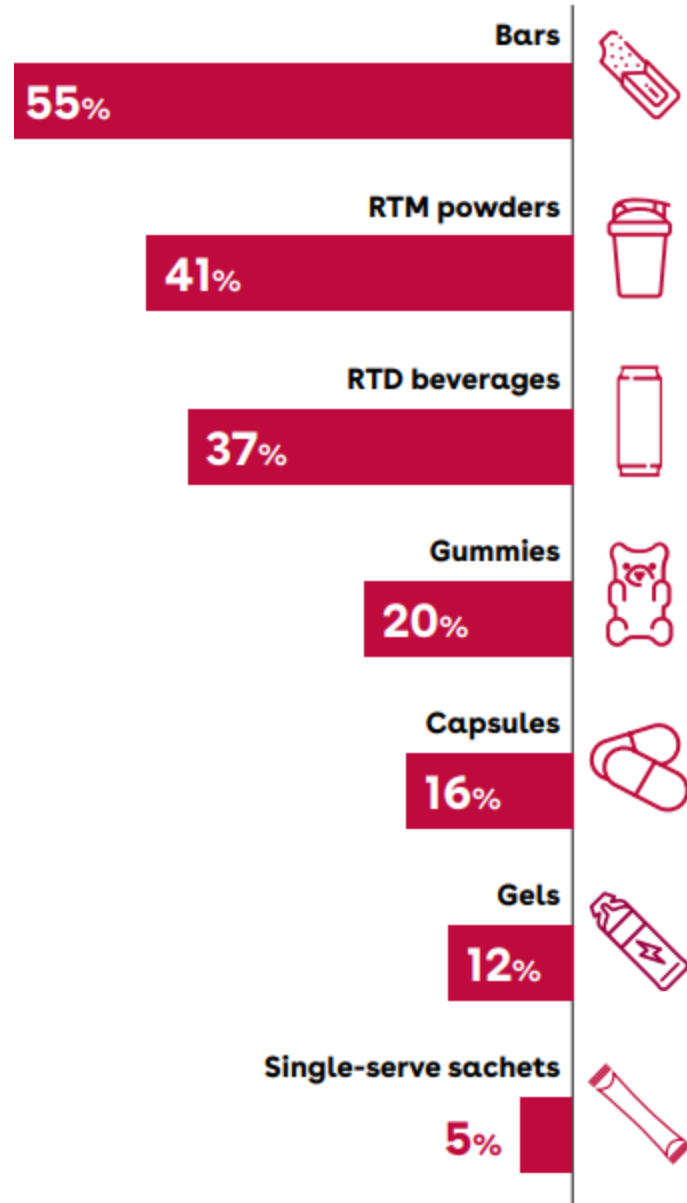
- **Performance Seekers:** Gym regulars and competitive athletes who want proven results, transparent labeling, and certifications such as Informed-Sport.
- **Everyday Wellness Users:** Use protein drinks, bars, and hydration products for daily energy and recovery; prefer natural, simple formulations.
- **Lifestyle Buyers:** Attracted to stylish, premium brands, influencer endorsements, and seasonal or limited-edition flavors.
- **Value Shoppers:** Price-sensitive buyers who look for promotions, bundles, or familiar mainstream brands.

Buying Behaviors & Motivations



Source-ResearchGate

**Sports nutrition formats with
the greatest consumer appeal:**

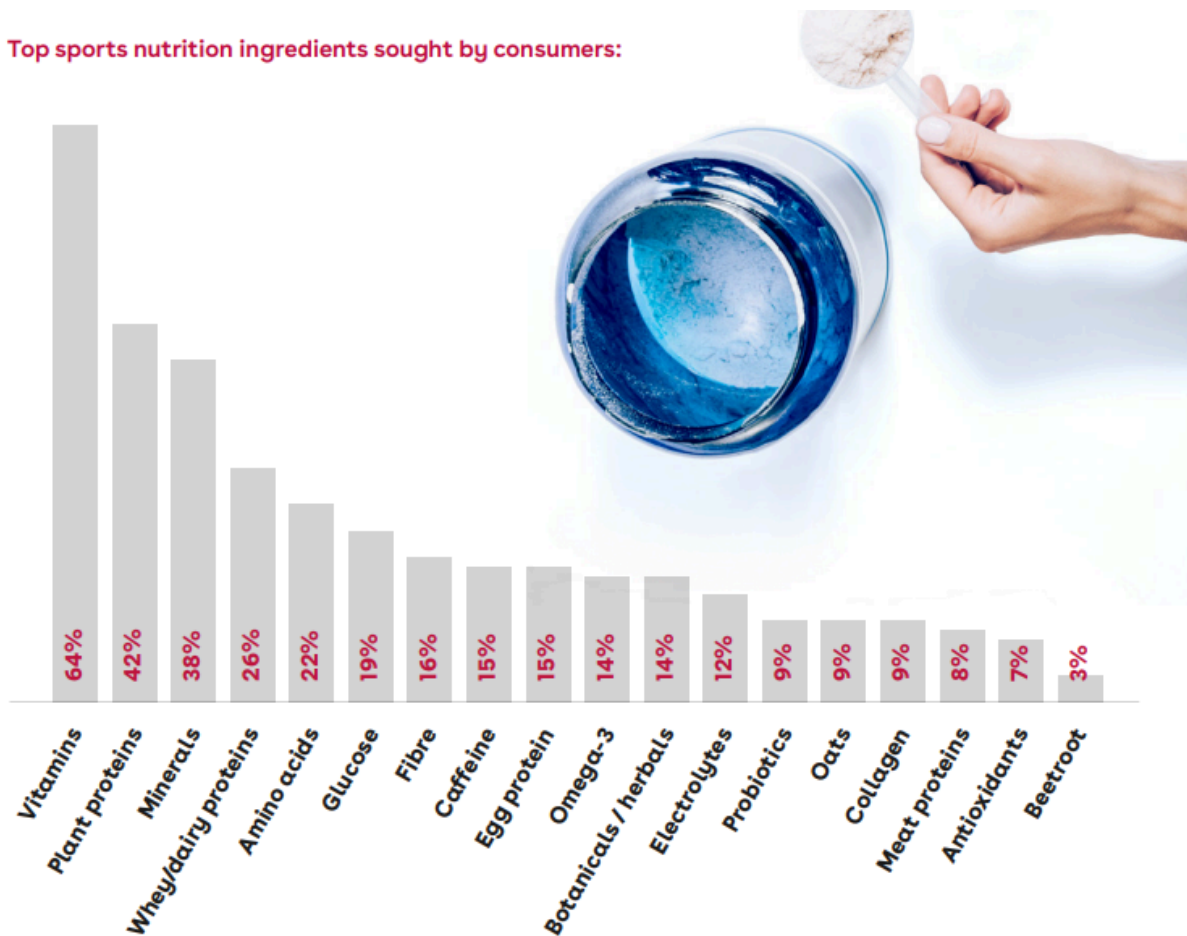


Source-Prinova Europe Ltd.

Key reasons for purchase include muscle growth, faster recovery, more energy, weight management, and joint/beauty benefits from collagen. Preferred formats vary:

- Powders for flexibility and value
- RTDs and bars for convenience
- Gummies and capsules for vitamins, minerals, and add-ons like creatine or collagen

Top sports nutrition ingredients sought by consumers:



Source-Prinova Europe Ltd.

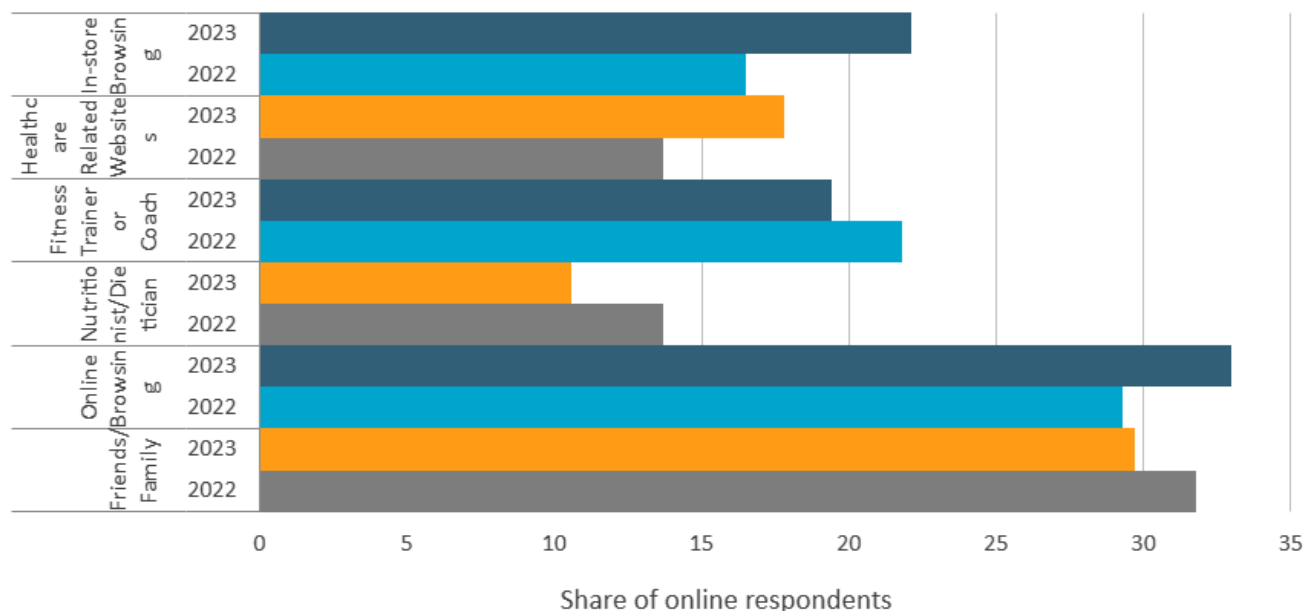
Top ingredient interests: Vitamins and proteins (plant and whey) lead, followed by minerals, amino acids, caffeine, omega-3s, botanicals, electrolytes, probiotics, and collagen.

Channels & Discovery

E-commerce and brand websites drive most discovery through reviews, social content, and subscriptions. In Germany, drugstores (dm, Rossmann) and pharmacies remain trusted retail points for quick, reliable purchases. Gyms and specialty shops serve more advanced or niche users.

Sports Nutrition Information Source in Germany

%



Source: Euromonitor International



Source- Euromonitor

Influence Pathways

Trainers, instructors, and health professionals are key influencers, often guiding first-time purchases of pre-workouts, protein, and hydration products. Online reviews, social media, and friends/family recommendations further shape buying decisions.

Competitive

Europe's sports nutrition market includes both global giants and strong regional brands. Each uses different strategies for product range, pricing, and sales channels. Most innovation is happening in ready-to-drink (RTD) products, plant-based proteins, and functional blends that add new benefits, helping brands grow both online and in stores.

Brands like Arla Ingredients, Multipower, Olimp, Scitec, Bulk, ESN, Foodspring, and Myprotein lead the European market. They focus heavily on protein-based products, launch new flavors quickly, and expand plant-based options. Most rely on direct-to-consumer (DTC) sales and tailor products to local tastes and regulations.

SWOT Analysis

Myprotein (THG)

- Strengths: Huge product range, frequent discounts, and a strong presence on their website and Amazon give them a wide reach across Europe.
- Weaknesses: Heavy discounting can make it look like a budget brand, reducing its premium appeal.
- Opportunities: Can grow premium and clean-label lines, and create gender-specific ranges to increase average selling price.
- Threats: Stricter regulations or ownership changes could impact pricing and service in key markets.

Foodspring (Germany)

- Strengths: Known for its premium German branding, stylish packaging, and range of high-quality proteins, bars, and functional foods.
- Weaknesses: Higher prices limit its audience, and recent ownership changes may affect innovation speed.
- Opportunities: Partnerships with gyms, trainers, and nutritionists could boost trust and expand its reach into wellness and female-focused categories.
- Threats: Competitors with lower prices and heavy digital advertising may erode market share.

ESN (Elite Sports Nutrition, Germany)

- Strengths: Very well-known in Germany with top-selling whey proteins and strong availability in drugstores.
- Weaknesses: Mixed online reviews about quality and pricing may slow premium product growth.
- Opportunities: Could expand into nearby countries and develop clean-label, certified products for serious athletes.
- Threats: Drugstore private labels copying their flavors and pricing can reduce shelf differentiation.

Optimum Nutrition (Glanbia)

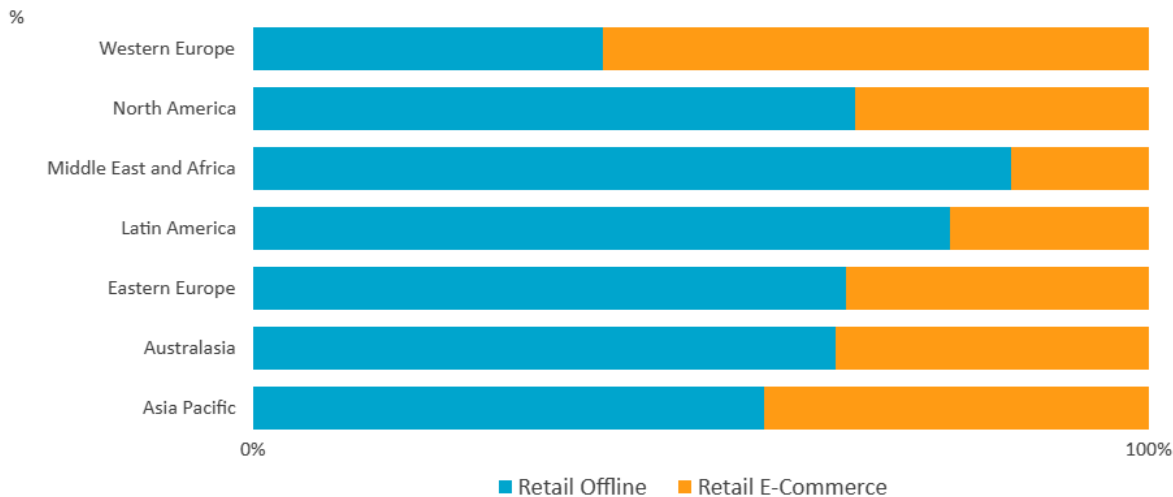
- Strengths: Trusted global brand known for consistent quality and third-party testing; strong reputation among athletes and specialty retailers.
- Weaknesses: Higher prices can limit competitiveness against cheaper online and DTC brands.
- Opportunities: Athlete partnerships and event sponsorships could boost its premium RTD and powder lines.
- Threats: Local online competitors and shifting retail trends toward private labels and fast-moving RTDs.

Bulk (UK)

- Strengths: Fast-moving DTC model, affordable pricing, and strong social media marketing. Expanding across Europe with local fulfillment centers.
- Weaknesses: Often seen as a commodity brand; it depends heavily on promotions and shipping efficiency.
- Opportunities: Setting up EU-based production, launching clean-label and plant-based products, and growing bar/RTD categories.
- Threats: Larger brands and retailer exclusives that dominate advertising space and store visibility.

Product range, pricing, distribution

Retail Channel Share



Source: Euromonitor International



Source- Euromonitor

- Product range spans powders, RTDs, bars, gels, electrolytes, creatine, BCAAs, and specialized pre-workouts aligned to energy, recovery, and endurance outcomes.
- Distribution mixes omnichannel: specialty retail, pharmacies, grocery/modern trade, DTC/e-commerce, and gym/shop-in-gym models; premium RTDs are increasingly visible in retail fridges.
- Pricing tiers: mainstream protein powders and sports drinks priced for volume, with premium plant-based, functional RTDs, and branded pre-workouts at higher price points to reflect ingredients and brand equity.

Regulatory & Compliance Overview

EU-wide rules

- Sports supplements are treated as foods, not medicines, so they follow EU food law for safety, composition, and labeling.
- Health and performance claims (e.g., “supports recovery”) must appear on the EU-authorized list and use approved wording. General statements like “source of protein” are allowed; disease or treatment claims are prohibited.

- Labels must meet Regulation (EU) 1169/2011 for ingredients, allergens, nutrition tables, quantities, and legibility, while supplement-specific rules are in Directive 2002/46/EC. Local language labeling is mandatory.
- Penalties for non-compliance include fines and product withdrawal.

Germany-specific rules

- Germany enforces EU law through the Food and Commodities Act (LFGB). Oversight is by the BVL and BfR.
- Supplements usually don't require pre-approval, but companies are responsible for safety, correct labeling, and compliance. Authorities can remove non-compliant products.
- Notification under NemV is required before selling supplements. Disease claims are prohibited; risk-reduction claims need EU authorization.

Required labeling in Germany

- Product name, recommended daily dose, active ingredients with amounts, nutrient reference values, ingredient list with allergens, batch/lot, best-before date, net quantity, storage instructions, warnings (e.g., "not a substitute for a varied diet"), and EU-based company contact.
- All information must be in German.

Distribution channels (Germany & Europe)

Online & Direct-to-Consumer (DTC)

- DTC websites and brand stores are ideal for niche SKUs, subscriptions, tutorials, and quick price/pack testing across borders. They provide higher margins and first-party data but need strong logistics, customer experience, and compliant claim copy in local languages.
- Marketplaces like Amazon drive high traffic and discovery, boost conversion with ratings, and support seasonal demand. Margins are lower due to fees and price competition.

Retail & Grocery

- Drugstores and supermarkets (dm, Rossmann, REWE, Edeka) now dedicate shelf and fridge space to high-protein products, RTDs, and bars, helping casual consumers discover and repeatedly buy sports nutrition.
- Pharmacies and specialist wellness retailers support premium, certified, or sport-focused products, offering guided selling, sampling, and cross-selling opportunities.

Partnership Channels

- Gyms, studios, clubs, and sports events allow targeted trials with coach recommendations, sampling, and bundle offers, building credibility. Partnerships with federations and teams strengthen performance positioning and create content for digital marketing.

Channel Roles

- DTC/Brand sites: Maximize margins, subscriptions, bundles, and consumer education.
- Marketplaces: Capture high-intent shoppers; ideal for multipacks and top flavors but require ad spend and compliance monitoring.
- Drugstores & supermarkets: Reach mainstream buyers with core powders, RTDs, and bars; support with fridges, endcaps, and clear benefit claims.

- Pharmacies & specialist stores: Position premium or niche lines; educate staff and provide samples to drive trade-up.
- Gyms & fitness clubs: Leverage coach endorsements, starter bundles, and loyalty perks for first purchase and routine formation.
- Wholesalers & distributors: Extend B2B reach in regions requiring local partners; ensure compliance and service standards.

Key German Distribution Partners

- dm & Rossmann: National placement for RTDs, bars, and mainstream powders; differentiation and velocity are crucial due to private labels.
- Amazon.de: Key for discovery, replenishment, and deal-led sales; optimize content, reviews, and subscriptions to maintain Buy Box and rankings.

Pricing Overview

- Protein powders (1 kg): €20–€80 depending on type, certification, and brand; mainstream tubs €25–€45, premium isolates €50–€80+.
- RTD shakes: €2–€4 per bottle; multipacks reduce per-unit cost.
- Bars/snacks: €1.50–€3 depending on protein, coatings, brand, and seasonal flavors.
- Capsules/vitamins: €10–€30 depending on count, dose, and claims.
- Pre-workouts: Mid-to-premium pricing; stick and RTD formats priced higher for convenience.

Marketing & Distribution Insights

Marketing Strategies That Work

- DTC funnels: Paid social ads to landing pages, driving subscriptions, and anchored by a hero SKU. Social proof, like reviews, user-generated content, and athlete endorsements, builds trust.
- Content & education: Science-backed explanations, coach tips, and compliant claims reduce hesitation and support premium pricing. Recipes encourage use beyond the gym.
- Sampling & trial: Single-serve packs, 500 g tubs, and gym/event sampling boost first purchases and repeat sales, especially for RTDs and new flavors.
- Marketplace PPC & subscriptions: Capture price-sensitive buyers with promotions like Subscribe & Save; pack sizes help protect margins.
- Influencer & community marketing: Micro-influencers and local coaches outperform celebrity reach for trust. Athlete partnerships add credibility but must follow EU claim rules.

Key Events & Expos

- FIBO (Cologne): Europe's top fitness expo—great for launches, retailer meetings, and coach/influencer activations.
- Fi Europe / Health Ingredients Europe: Source ingredients, co-develop products, and validate clean-label or plant-based innovations.
- Nutraceutical & regulatory summits: Stay updated on claims, botanicals, and novel-food approvals that affect product launches.

Distribution Channels

- Online & DTC: Ideal for niche SKUs, subscriptions, reviews, tutorials, and testing prices/pack sizes. High margins and first-party data come with strong logistics, CX, and compliant labeling.
- Marketplaces (e.g., Amazon): Drive discovery, search-led shopping, and seasonal demand; margins are lower due to fees and price competition.
- Retail & Grocery: German drugstores and supermarkets (dm, Rossmann, REWE, Edeka) dedicate more shelf/fridge space to RTDs, bars, and powders, making sports nutrition mainstream.
- Pharmacies & Specialist Stores: Build trust for premium, certified, or sport-focused products; useful for guided selling, sampling, and cross-selling accessories.
- Gyms & Sports Clubs: Coach endorsements, bundles, and sampling drive first purchases and routine formation.
- Wholesalers & Distributors: Expand B2B reach across regions needing local partners; align on compliance and service SLAs.

Competitor Positioning

- Value DTC & marketplace brands: Focus on price, bundles, and promotions; trade margin for sales volume.
- Premium DTC & boutique brands: Charge higher prices with clean-label messaging, flavor innovation, packaging, and community programs; succeed in pharmacies, specialist stores, and curated online shops.
- Global brands: Maintain premium positioning with trust, certifications, and consistent quality, while expanding RTDs for convenience.

Opportunities & Niche Growth

- Female-focused products: Flavor, macros, formats, and branding that appeal beyond “male-gym” cues.
- Plant-based and clean-label products: Attract flexitarians, lactose-sensitive consumers, and sustainability-conscious buyers.
- Functional everyday formats: Collagen coffee, protein cereals, and high-protein meals for non-gym occasions.
- Personalization & subscriptions: Tailored blends, micro-dose packs, and monthly replenishment to boost retention.
- Private-label partnerships: Collaborate with leading drugstores/grocers to secure shelf space and volume.

Risks & Barriers

- Regulatory complexity: Claims, botanicals, and novel foods require careful compliance; only use authorized wording.
- Price pressure: Promo-heavy DTC brands, private labels, and marketplace fees can squeeze margins; differentiate with flavor, format, certifications, and community.
- Competitive retail listings: Shelf and fridge space require proof of velocity, clear benefits, and strong launch plans.
- Supply chain & ingredient quality: Third-party testing, GMP, and athlete certifications are essential where performance claims are implied.

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